players and their choices generate and explain foreign policy outcomes, Russian neoliberalism and the social reproduction of its elite provide the broad frame for the Kremlin's international stance.

A key element here is the 'energy weapon' (as we saw, so central in Putin's plans for a restored Great Russia). If the view proposed here is right, the energy weapon is not only a diplomatic instrument, but a source of economic value and political stability essential if Russian neoliberalism, in its current form, is to survive and reproduce. Critically, the imperialist character of the Russian neoliberal state is not only discernible in the assertive and at times aggressive character of Russian foreign policy (particularly in what is called its 'near abroad'), but it is also now recognised as such by its competitors in the system – and this is one of the key political lessons from the Ukrainian conflict. Indeed, let's ask ourselves what the West's overall reaction to the annexation of Crimea has been, and how the US and its allies have applied their punitive measures to the Russian state. Revealingly, the answer is that the West has explicitly targeted the Russian ruling class (or, as the preferred media formula has it, 'Putin's circle' – needless to say that the broader economic pain will be felt by all Russians, especially the most economically vulnerable). As Karen Dawisha puts it:

> [after Crimea] individual Russian citizens would be subjected to asset seizures and visa bans. The Sixth Fleet was not called into action; exports to Russia as a whole were not banned; cultural and educational exchanges were not stopped. Rather, individual elites close to 'a senior Russian Government official' – Vladimir Putin – were targeted. Probably the most serious international crisis since the end of the Cold War, and the White House targets individuals. Why this response? Because at last, after fourteen years of dealing with President Vladimir Putin as a legitimate head of state, the U.S. government has finally acknowledged publicly what successive administrations have known privately – that he has built a system based on massive predation on a level not seen in Russia since the tsars (2014:7).

And, we might add, this Russian 'system' is in no way a hostile entity threatening Western capitalism from the outside, but only one of its instantiations. It cannot be understood but as a partial product of Western intervention in the 1990s (in particular by both Clinton administrations), during the transition to the free market.